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## Preliminary investigation report

# Rejected take-off and runway overrun, Tarlton Springs

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## Summary

On 18/06/2026, Saltbush Air SB512, a twin-turboprop registered VH-SBQ, began its take-off from runway 09 at Tarlton Springs Aerodrome. The crew saw two kangaroos on the runway and rejected the take-off. The aircraft struck both animals and stopped 62 m into the runway end safety area. None of the 47 people on board was seriously injured, although one cabin crew member reported bruising. The aircraft was substantially damaged and both kangaroos were killed. The aerodrome was closed for 4 hours 20 minutes.

The investigation is examining how the animals reached the runway, runway inspection after last light, the approval of the evening service, and the rejected take-off and stop. Two further questions remain open. The first is whether the crew were fatigued. The second is whether four edge lights, measured above nominal intensity, affected when the animals were seen.

In the interim, the operator suspended the evening service on 19/06/2026 and has listed Tarlton Springs for runway inspection after last light. The aerodrome operator, for its part, is replacing the 140 m section of its northern boundary fence.

## What we know

On 18/06/2026 Saltbush Air SB512, a 50-seat twin-turboprop registered VH-SBQ, was to depart Tarlton Springs Aerodrome for Port Carrick on the last scheduled sector of the day. On board were 44 passengers, 2 flight crew and 1 cabin crew. It was the fifth sector of the flight crew's duty. The evening rotation had been added to that duty the same morning, after a member of the rostered crew reported unfit. The aerodrome's only runway inspection that day was made at 21:35 UTC on 17/06/2026, before the first arrival, and it recorded the movement area as clear.

The doors closed at 07:16 UTC, on schedule. Tarlton Springs has no control tower. The crew therefore made their own broadcasts on the common traffic advisory frequency (CTAF), and they switched on the pilot-activated runway lighting at 07:21:50. The aircraft lined up on runway 09 in darkness, with the AWIS wind at 090 at 6 kt. Neither the crew nor the aerodrome raised a runway inspection. The first officer was flying. The take-off roll began at 07:30:02 (17:30 local), and the captain called V1 at 112 kt at 07:30:29.

At 07:30:31 the first officer called two kangaroos moving onto the runway from the northern side, past the 1,100 m point. Their range at first sight is estimated at around 200 m. One second later the captain took control and rejected the take-off at 118 kt, six knots above V1. Flight data places the aircraft 1,152 m along the runway at that moment, with 695 m of sealed surface remaining. About one second after that, the right main landing gear and the No. 2 propeller struck both animals. Maximum braking was established at 07:30:34. Reverse was then selected on No. 1 only, because No. 2 reverse did not engage.

The aircraft left the end of runway 09 at approximately 21 kt at 07:30:51. It stopped at 07:30:57, 62 m into the 90 m runway end safety area and 28 m short of its end, upright and on the extended centreline. There was no fire. The captain shut down both engines and did not command an evacuation. At the captain's request on the CTAF, the aerodrome reporting officer activated the aerodrome emergency plan, sent a vehicle and closed the aerodrome. Passengers left by the forward airstair. The occurrence notification puts this at 4 minutes 8 seconds after the aircraft stopped, and the CVR records the airstair operating at 07:34:40.

Three No. 2 propeller blades were damaged beyond limits, and that engine needs a shock-load inspection. The right main gear doors were distorted. Both right main tyres deflated through their fuse plugs, and the brakes absorbed 84% of their certified maximum energy. The lower right fuselage was punctured. Nobody was seriously injured. One cabin crew member reported bruising during the disembarkation. Both kangaroos were killed, and the aerodrome was closed for 4 hours 20 minutes.

## What we are looking at

1. **How the animals reached the runway.** The investigation is examining the northern perimeter fence and the aerodrome's use of its wildlife sighting log. Works register item WR-221 recorded the fence as failed in 04/2023, and the repair was deferred at three budget rounds. An animal pad through the fence at the 1,050 m mark (Figure 1) lies 138 m before the first carcass, on the same side of the runway.



*Figure 1: The northern perimeter fence at the 1,050 m mark, photographed on the site visit: the fallen section and the animal pad through it. Site inspection photograph SV-2026-0417-07, northern boundary at the 1,050 m runway marker, taken 23/06/2026*

2. **Wildlife requirements for aerodromes of this size.** Tarlton Springs falls below both thresholds in AS-139 10.4.2. It was therefore not required to hold a documented wildlife hazard management plan, and it held none. The investigation is examining what that threshold means given a logged history of kangaroos on the movement area.

3. **Runway inspection after last light.** Operations Manual Part A 8.14 requires an inspection only at aerodromes listed in Appendix 8A. Listing follows a reported wildlife strike, and Tarlton Springs has never been listed. The investigation is examining that criterion and why no inspection was requested before SB512 departed.

4. **Approval of the evening service.** CMR-2025-118 introduced the evening rotation as a schedule change only. It did not reopen the daylight-only restriction in route risk assessment RRA-041. SB512 began its roll after the end of civil twilight, and the investigation is examining how the change was assessed.

5. **The rejected take-off and the stop.** The decision to reject 6 kt above V1 is being examined against Operations Manual Part B 4.6 and recurrent training syllabus TRG-SYL-07. Neither contains a runway obstruction scenario. The stopping performance is also being examined, as the strike left reverse thrust on No. 1 only.

6. **Cabin floor escape path lighting.** A functional check found two floor proximity segments on VH-SBQ dark because of a failed ballast. The pre-flight test does not cover them. Engineering is examining whether the part is fitted across the fleet.

Two matters remain open. One is whether the flight crew were fatigued at take-off. The other is whether four northern edge lights, measured above nominal intensity seven days later, affected when the animals were seen.

## Containment and next steps

Three interim actions have been taken since the occurrence. They are reported as actions taken in the interim, not as evidence of what caused it.

- The Head of Flying Operations suspended the evening Tarlton Springs service on 19/06/2026. [NOT ESTABLISHED: whether the suspension remains in place]
- On 26/06/2026 the Head of Flying Operations amended Appendix 8A by temporary revision TR-2026-04 to list Tarlton Springs. The Part A 8.14.2 runway inspection now applies to every departure there after last light, pending a permanent change. This action is in place.
- The aerodrome operator has funded works register item WR-221 from its 2026 contingency. A temporary electric wire was installed on 25/06/2026. Replacement of the 140 m northern boundary fence section is programmed for 09/2026, and this action is still being implemented.

The investigation has also recommended that the operator change the Appendix 8A listing criterion and add a route risk assessment trigger for any aerodrome first operated into after last light. A response was due by 30/09/2026, and the recommendation remains open. No safety action has been recorded on training and guidance for a runway obstruction, the approval of the evening service, the evening rotation roster, or floor escape path lighting.

The investigation's next steps are:

- Engineering is establishing whether the failed ballast part is fitted across the fleet, and how many aircraft are inside the 24-month test interval now.
- The investigation is still examining whether the four northern edge lights affected when the animals were seen.
- Someone outside the investigation will review the draft report. The people and organisations it describes will then be invited to correct matters of fact.

The final report is expected [NOT ESTABLISHED: expected date of the final report].

## Distribution

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